THE PRACTICAL MINI GUIDE

Starting a business in Switzerland

Permission, business structure, insurance and tax questions to resolve before your first order.



Inside this guide

Permission and genuine self-employment / Sole proprietorship or GmbH / Accounting, social insurance and pricing

GOOD TO KNOW

01 Permission and genuine self-employment

The ability to establish a company and permission to personally work in it are separate questions. They depend on residence documentation, the activity and the cantonal procedure. Recognition of self-employment for social insurance is another assessment: actual working arrangements, entrepreneurial risk and customer relationships matter. Calling a contract freelance does not determine its status by itself. Regulated professions may also require a specific licence or recognition of qualifications before services can be offered.

02 Sole proprietorship or GmbH

A sole proprietorship and a GmbH differ in liability, formation and accounting requirements. Simpler administration does not mean the absence of personal financial risk. A separate legal entity brings its own formation and operating costs. Commercial-register entry, tax registration and recognition of self-employment by the compensation office are not interchangeable procedures. The structure should match the business's actual revenue, service risks and plans to involve partners. The official SME portal explains the available forms and their implications.

GOOD TO KNOW

03 Accounting, social insurance and pricing

Money arriving in a business account is not the same as personal profit. Materials, rent, bookkeeping, social contributions, insurance and tax obligations must be financed from that revenue. VAT depends on the rules applicable to the activity rather than merely the fact that a first sale has occurred. Separate records of income and expenditure make the financial result understandable. For example, an hourly service price must also cover preparation and administrative time that may not appear as separate lines on the customer’s invoice.

04 First customers and professional networks

A clear offer explains the scope of work, deliverable, price, additional costs and payment arrangements. Written conditions help align expectations about timing and cancellation. Cantonal economic-development services and relevant professional associations can provide entry points into the local business environment. Ukrainian communities can make introductions easier, but a personal recommendation alone does not establish an adviser’s qualifications. Experience in the relevant canton and industry is more useful than a general promise of a quick launch.

Good to know

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Sources and useful links

ch.ch — moving to Switzerland

KMU Portal — setting up a business

KMU Portal — self-employment formalities

The procedure depends on residence documentation, activity and location. The primary sources below help clarify the requirements for your circumstances.

Explore more on Sweezy